

TAMBARAM

Chromepet » Pallavaram » Tambaram West » Rajakilpakkam » Mannivakkam » Guindy » Keelkattalai » Nanganallur » Guduvanchery » Hasthinapuram » Pammal » Tambaram East

Medavakkam » Srinivasa Nagar » Kathipara Junction » Kovilambakkam » Sadasivam Nagar » Potheri » Selaiyur » Sembakkam » St.Thomas Mount » Madipakkam » Urappakkam » Paranur



OVERFLOWING SEWAGE: RESIDENTS WANT PERMANENT SOLUTION

At Bharathi Nagar in Guindy, the condition of a collection well is a huge cause for concern **P2**



FISHING FOR GHOST NETS

Through its Sea Turtle Protection Force, TREE Foundation has built an army of fishers who retrieve ghost nets from the sea **P5**

READERS WRITE

'Lock Tambaram subway until work is completed'

S. POORNIMA SUBRAMANIAN

In May, the Tambaram City Municipal Corporation announced that it will revamp the pedestrian subway connecting Major Mukund Varadhara-
jan Road and GST Road.

Except for cleaning, scrapping and painting the subway walkway (outside the underpass), and the walls, no other work has been done.

Unless the revamp is undertaken it is better to lock the subway. It is a trash yard, a tippler's den, and a free washroom.

The ceilings are cracked and water drips from the ceilings, stagnating on the walkway, resulting in a slippery surface.

Some pedestrians use the subway. Vegetation is sprouting on the



The entrance to the subway from GST Road, West Tambaram; and stagnant water . PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



walkway, which can damage the structure.

The electrical equipment is broken, and the lights are missing.

The subway needs a security guard or should be locked.

S. Poornima Subramanian is a retired school teacher and a long-time resident of East Tambaram

Waiting for the Metro



Work is fast under way on corridor-5 of Chennai Metro Rail that extends from Porur to Poonamallee Bypass on Mount - Poonamallee Road. PHOTO: B. VELANKANNI RAJ

A pedestrian signal is needed at MM Nagar Municipality office junction

T.S. ATUL SWAMINATHAN

A pedestrian signal is needed at this junction where GST Road Service Lane and Maraimalai Nagar Municipality Office Road intersect.

Although a footbridge is within half-a-kilometre, the pedestrian facility serves only bus commuters and pedestrians around Vallal Adhiyaman Salai and Vallal MGR Street.

At the junction, motorists from Singaperumal Kovil region enter the service lane, take a U-turn, and enter Mun-

icipality Office Road; from Kattankalathur, motorists take a U-turn. In addition, motorists on GST Road jump signals.

R. Bharat, a resident of Maraimalai Nagar, says, "Following an accident involving a woman, we have been demanding that the traffic wing of the Tambaram Police Commissionerate facilitate a pedestrian signal, but a vehicle-signaled junction has been installed. Pedestrians cannot walk to the bus stop, come here, and go towards Kattankulathur. A pedestrian signal is needed. Pedestrians run and dodge vehicles."





T. ARVIND

Ever since the walkers' pathway along the rejuvenated Chitlapakkam Lake was opened to the public in 2023, hundreds of residents, including youngsters and senior citizens, have been using it regularly.

With LED lamps illuminating the lake after dusk, women can be seen in considerable numbers even after 7 p.m.

For Shruthika, a college student, evenings on most of her days off are spent at the lake. "I like the ambience and the surroundings," she said. However, she added that a few recent irritants were beginning to overshadow the otherwise pleasant experience.

One of her concerns was the mushrooming of "karaoke" culture in public spaces, which, she said,

had now reached the lake too.

According to officials, a karaoke orchestra by a retired insurance officer was being conducted to raise funds for visually challenged artists and underprivileged families, with the approval of the relevant authorities. "We are not complaining about them," Shruthika said, acknowledging that the evening performances at the designated

spot near the Lake Park were welcomed by walkers. *The Hindu Downtown* had reported on the orchestra and its charitable cause in its January 18, 2026 edition.

However, Shruthika and another senior citizen who regularly walk at the lake said that, over the past month, a pair of youngsters had begun regularly singing karaoke songs about 100 metres

A karaoke performance and (right) overgrown bushes along the Chitlapakkam Lake pathway that walkers want the Corporation to clear. PHOTOS: T. ARVIND



Murmur over lake karaoke

Not all visitors to the Chitlapakkam Lake find the music pleasing and want such performances restricted

away from the orchestra, on the western side of the lake.

"After a long walk, this is where many senior citizens prefer to sit and enjoy the breeze. But this latest 'entertainment' disturbs the ambience and even affects a casual conversation among us," said the senior citizen. "With due respect to their interests, I only appeal to them to choose another platform for 'practice', as they call it."

Walkers and activists have urged the Tambaram Corporation and the law-enforcement authorities to prevent individuals or groups from misusing public spaces or violating norms. "Talent grooming cannot be done at the expense of the general public," said another walker, Henry. "When commuters are instructed to use earphones instead of speakers from mobile even on the Metro Rail, how can peace be

disturbed at such an ambient place?" he wondered. He also felt that no more such orchestras should be allowed to 'perform' at the lake.

When contacted, a sanitary inspector of the Corporation, Chitlapakkam zone said no permission had been given either to the public or individuals to conduct unauthorised concerts along the lake pathway. "We will check and ensure that there is no disturbance to the public," he said.

Other concerns

Shruthika also flagged the overgrown bushes along the southern end of the pathway, adjacent to the burial ground complex. She said the bushes needed to be cleared as the area was frequented by reptiles and other insects.

Another issue flagged by regular visitors to the lake is despite the presence of volunteers and the police, some motorists continue to park their vehicles right in front of the entrance gate on Chitlapakkam Main Road. The Corporation had recently provided parking facilities at two designated locations nearby, which can accommodate more than 100 vehicles.

Walkers have also suggested that the lake pathway be kept open until 9.30 p.m., as many office-goers return home only around 8 p.m. or later.

A simple roof-like shelter at one or two designated spots along the 1-km pathway could also be considered. "During sudden rain, it will be helpful to take shelter, and provide some relief to security personnel during their patrol," a visitor said.

Overflowing sewage: residents want permanent solution

At Bharathi Nagar in Guindy, the condition of a collection well is a huge cause for concern

T.S. ATUL SWAMINATHAN

Residents of Bharathi Nagar in Guindy have requested the Adyar zone of Chennai Metropolitan Water Supply and Sewerage Board (CMWSSB) to level the manhole and collection well at the Board's sewage pumping station on Tank Street.

S. Narayanan, a long-time resident of Guindy and a social activist, says, "Sewage from homes on Pillayar Koil Street, Ambedkar Street, Nethaji Street, Krishna-moorthy Street, MGR Street, Bharathi Street, and Tank Street in

the locality drains into the manhole, but it is unable to enter the collection well because of its elevated position."

As a result, sewage overflows from the manhole on Tank Street, making life difficult for pedestrians and motorists.

Every time we have to call the helpline number to pump the water from the manhole and from the street. Though the workers do clean, the problem resurfaces, the sewage flows on the stretch, creating a breeding ground for mosquitoes and a health hazard for residents of Tank Street and Thiruvalluvar Street in Race View



A COMMON SIGHT AT TANK STREET. THIS IMAGE WAS TAKEN ON SEPTEMBER 23, 2026. PHOTO: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Colony, say residents.

Hundreds of bus and train commuters take this stretch, and the sight of overflowing sewage presents a dirty picture.

S. Evangeline, a senior citizen and a resident of Guindy, says, "The lighting is poor on the stretch after sunset, some use the torchlight on their phones to not

step on the sewage. We have requested CMWSSB to level the manhole and the collection well infrastructure, but no action has been taken to date."

No pavements on this stretch of GST Road



Motorcyclists driving in the wrong direction in Potheri. PHOTO: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

T.S. ATUL SWAMINATHAN

This section of Potheri witnesses heavy vehicular movement. It needs a safe pavement for pedestrians, specifically from the exit service lane in Potheri to the entry service lane in Mettukuppam.

On this section of GST Road, the carriageway sees wrong-side driving.

Motorists from Raghavendiran Nagar, Sadasivam Road, and Ninakalai localities in Mettukuppam heading to Thiruvalluvar Street, Bharathi Street, Kambar Street, and Pillaiyar Kovil Street, Potheri, have to take a U-turn on GST Road, along Level Crossing 44 Road. But they drive in the wrong direction on GST Road.

S. Varun, a two-wheeler rider, says, "It is better to ride along the median, as the motorists jump lanes, posing a risk to their counterparts driving towards Maraimalai Nagar."

The motorists near the localities drive at a high speed and change direction. Motorists also drive too close to their counterparts on GST Road, forcing them to swerve right and risking collisions."

K. Anjali, a pedestrian, says, "A wide walkway with bollards and boundary railings should be constructed. There are three schools and students and pedestrians are at risk. Motorists scare pedestrians by honking. The pedestrians' movement is affected. Accidents can occur between motorists and pedestrians, and motorists".

Restore road near Camp Road junction

BEENA ANIL

The main road near the Camp Road junction towards Thiruvenceri was dug up for laying sewage pipelines, carried out by CMWSSB. Instead of levelling the road properly, they are left bumpy, dusty and patchy, causing risk to commuters, motorists and pedestrians alike. Even

more alarming is the condition of the iron barricades, which were used to cover the pits, some of them are protruding that can be dangerous particularly at night when visibility is poor. I urge the authorities to ensure proper restoration of roads after pipeline work and avoid temporary patchwork.

Beena Anil is a resident of Shridhi Sai Nagar, Thiruvenceri



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Hindustan University brings student-athletes for volleyball and football tourney

This annual event is being conducted since 2019 to honour the vision of Elizabeth Verghese, Founder Chancellor

The winning volleyball teams from SRM Institute of Science & Technology and Vels University

release. The tournament, held from September 21 to 23, was inaugurated in the presence of Vice-Chancellor Vikas Misra and Registrar Dr. S.S.Rao.

Former International Volleyball Player and South Asian Games Gold Medallist A. Sivaraman attended as the chief guest, alongside Ganesh Prabhu, an alumnus of HITS and Global Head of Strategic Partnerships at Aspin Holdings LLC Dubai. The dignitaries presented championship trophies, medals, and cash prizes totalling ₹1.5 lakh to the winning teams, added the release.

Tournament winners

Men's Football: Champions - SRM Institute of Science & Technology (SRM IST), Chennai

Men's Volleyball: Champions - SRM Institute of Science & Technology (SRM IST), Chennai

Women's Volleyball: Champions - Vels University

Runners-Up & other Finishes: Tamil Nadu Physical Education and Sports University (TNPEU), Vinayaka Mission's Research Foundation (Chennai Campus), and host teams from Hindustan University.

More than 450 student-athletes across 15 universities and institutions took part in the 'Founder Chancellor Trophy 2026' organised by the Department of Physical Education and Sports Sciences at Hindustan Institute of Technology and Science at its Padur campus.

The participant line-up includ-

ed 252 men's football players, 135 men's volleyball players, and 72 women's volleyball players. Organised annually since 2019, the Founder Chancellor Trophy honours the vision of Elizabeth Verghese, Founder Chancellor, reflecting the institution's commitment to fostering sportsmanship, youth development, teamwork, and excellence, said a



Old Markets, New Trends is a column that features markets that have continued to retain their hold on people's mindscape despite the shifting sands of fads. Through entities that have been around for a long time, it seeks to find out what makes these markets tick

Tarpaulin is just the 'trailer'

LAKSHMY HARIKRISHNAN

Umbrellas are a victim of "folk association". They are certainly not the sole preserve of the monsoon with its drippy skies, but that is the period they get busier and therefore, get almost entirely associated with the rains. The tarpaulin shops at Nehru Market on Sydenhams Road in Periamet are busy through the year and get a tad busier when the monsoon is round the corner.

But one peek into these tarpaulin shops and there is not a shred of doubt about their all-year relevance. And now, tarpaulin seems like a generic term for a whole range of products that offer a protective cover to valuables. These shops sell those green shade nets for gardens, tents for camping, cotton canvas covers, car covers and bags (which are also covers, glorified covers). These bags are not high-fashion, but made of heavy-duty material and designed to last.

Tarpaulins of various thickness and materials, both determining their prices, are a dominant presence, but one can always shop for more than tarpaulins.

At Nehru Market, there is more to the tarpaulin shops than their name suggests. Their range includes camp tents for the outdoor-oriented and shade nets for those with a green thumb. With the NE monsoon (when they are a tad busier) just weeks away, a look at what helps them cope with changing buyer behaviour



Tarpaulin shops at Nehru Market. PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Nehru Market is next door to Anna Market, which is dominated by sale of metal items, many of them massive spare parts that go into the running of industrial machinery. The first few shops at Nehru Market are tarpaulin shops, wholesale and retail, but step in-

side and the shops selling spare parts for industrial machinery predominate. These two markets are not next door neighbours but closer than that, as united as two intercommunicating rooms with a common door. The tarpaulin shops and those selling used spare parts for

industrial machinery exist side by side, by design.

Anil Kumar of Prakash Trading Company points out that these tarpaulin covers are used to cover machinery, among other things. While out here to purchase metal parts for heavy-duty industrial machinery, someone might pick up tarpaulins too. These shops also draw adventurers who like to camp out in a temporary shelter under the skies. Similarly, those with a green thumb. The green shade nets are for them.

Anil Kumar notes that almost every shop, the wholesale shops for certain, would have a tailor attached to it. The tents, shade nets and cotton canvas have to be made to order, often. Promptness is a key factor driving success and survival in this business.

Many of these tarpaulin shops are carryovers from a different era, one pithily defined as "Moore Market". Following the Moore Market fire in the 1980s, traders fanned out depending on where they were allocated a space. That is how some

of the tarpaulin sellers ended up in Nehru Market, managed by Greater Chennai Corporation.

Anil Kumar shoulders the weight of a legacy: the shop was established by his father Narayan Jha over 50 years ago. He worked alongside his father and brother before their deaths, and now the weight of that legacy is entirely on his shoulders. And he finds it to be excruciatingly heavy not only due to the lack of support from a kindred soul, but also market realities. "Counter sales has dwindled," says Anil. "Demand has generally fallen with online shopping changing the way customers buy."

So this is where it stands: much of the regular business comes from factories that use the material to cover machinery, as well as from transporters. Anil qualifies that, saying there is still demand for shade nets, tents, car covers and other items but there is huge competition from various quarters.

The promise of getting items at wholesale rates or even purse-friendly retail rates continues to hold out an attraction for the cost-conscious, and they hit Nehru market. Another shop seller, who does not want to be named, points out that tarpaulins, camping tents and car covers are available at wholesale prices on a section of Walltax Road, largely Ramanan Road and near Elephant Gate Street. But Nehru Market in Sydenhams Road scores on ease of access.

LIFFY THOMAS

More than 11,500 kilos of abandoned, lost or discarded fishing nets, known as ghost nets, were collected in the last three months from the Chennai coast, largely from the Neelankarai-to-Kovalam section. That is just the tip of the iceberg. Tonnes of them are yet to be retrieved from our long coastline, many entangled around marine animals preventing them from moving freely.

“In fact, when the North East Monsoon sets in, the quantity of ghost nets being collected also increases depending on the wind pattern seen during the months of October to March. From December onwards, the ghost nets are observed floating closer to the shore,” says Supraja Dharani, founder of TREE Foundation, a Chennai-based non-governmental organisation that focuses on marine conservation.

Since 2021, the Foundation has been playing a key role in removing tonnes of ghost nets by empowering different stakeholders attached to the seas, the local community and the fishers being their chief ambassadors.

As part of capacity building programmes, they conduct workshops to train fishers in identifying and retrieving a net by steering their boats towards it, looking for marine species in the net, releasing it and pulling the net closer to the boat and bringing it to the shores where it is weighed and sent for recycling.

Tree Foundation currently works in the Chennai-Chengalpattu stretch of the coast, many parts of Andhra Pradesh starting from Sullurpeta, Bapatla, Prakasham, Godavari, Vizianagaram and Srikakulam, southern Odisha and western Goa.

Sea Turtle Protection Force

“Our work in retrieving ghost nets extends to more than 800 km, 285 fishing villages, and 411 fishing



Fishing for ghost nets

Through its Sea Turtle Protection Force, TREE Foundation has built an army of fishers who retrieve ghost nets from the sea



An awareness programme by TREE Foundation for fishermen about ghost nets; and (above) fishermen retrieve abandoned nets.

community members who are part of the Sea Turtle Protection Force; they are the point of contact for fishers of the respective villages,”

says Supraja.

One of the biggest motivations for fishers to retrieve ghost nets is the incentive they receive for the

quantity they collect.

The amount of payment depends on the weight of the net. “Fifty percent of the amount goes to their bank account and the rest to the wife’s or mother’s account, which is used for children’s education, repair of nets and medical emergencies,” says the marine activist.

In the last five years, 217 tonnes of ghost nets have been handed to the TREE Foundation. To further felicitate those who have removed the maximum quantity of ghost nets, a felicitation event is held, usually in the first week of October, where other stakeholders including officers from the Coast Guard and Fisheries department are invited.

“Our success is the result of awareness programmes that we conduct teaching the fisherman how to release entangled endangered marine life including turtles, retrieve the ghost net and hand it over to TREE Foundation. Till date 974 marine megafauna have been released by the fishermen all recorded by videos or photos,” she

says.

The abandoned nets are weighed and sent for recycling. The Foundation has made a pathway at its biodiversity centre in Marakkanam.

Finding corporates willing to support the programme financially is a challenge, and Supraja says they are grateful to be supported by Royal Enfield and AstraZeneca in the ghost net retrieval and incentivisation programme for fishermen along Chengalpattu and Chennai coast.

The weight of these nets range from 100 to 700 kilos and tying it to their boats and bringing it to the shore is not easy.

“We want more corporates to support us in other coastal areas as well. We are soon going to set up a small unit where the nets will be shredded and made into small tiles,” she says. More support from corporates would mean getting more fishermen to join the diving team.

Removing ghost nets entangled in coral reefs will also be an extension of Foundation’s work.

Extending from coast to coast

BY A SPECIAL CORRESPONDENT

If you are a certified diver then HCL Foundation, the CSR arm of HCL Technologies, should be happy to engage your service to scour the ocean depths for ghost nets. Under HCL Harit, the Foundation has been playing a key role in removing ghost nets.

Started in 2022 from the Chennai coast in Neelankarai, today the initiative extends along the Gulf of Mannar, coasts along Karnataka, Andhra Pradesh and Odisha.

As per data, they have successfully mapped, retrieved, and repurposed nearly 4 lakh plus kilograms of abandoned, lost or discarded fishing gear (ALDFG), across several distinct coastal locations in India.

In the Gulf of Mannar, more than 12.9 metric tons of ghost nets have been removed from ecologically sensitive habitats surrounding 21 islands. In Kundapura, Karnataka, they have launched an innovative buy-back model that incentivises fishers to return dis-

carded nets, helping recover over 10,000 kg of ghost gear.

Nidhi Pundhir, vice-president - Global CSR, HCL Tech and Director, HCL Foundation, says they have a MoU with the Ministry of Environment, and over the years they have built a nationwide coalition involving scientific institutions, diving teams, fisher communities, the Indian Coast Guard, coastal police, and grassroot organisations to tackle marine debris.

A dedicated ghost gear man-

agement component was integrated into the Fisher Friend Mobile Application, enabling real time tracking and reporting of ghost gear by fishing communities.

Nidhi says there is a whole process involved in recycling the ghost nets that serves as a supplementary income for communities. “When we get these nets, they have a whole lot of salt coating on it and is not easily recyclable. We are doing a lot of R&D including converting them into nets which are used for various sports activities, designing bags and for other creative use,” says Nidhi.

To engage university students

to design upcycled, functional products from the retrieved nylons, the Foundation conducted the Ghost Net Innovation Challenge. Recently, on International Coastal Cleanup Day, the Foundation organised a mega cleanup campaign of oceans, involving volunteer and community members.

“From CSR design point of view, we have been thinking that we really need to take a district-level kind of an approach in certain places where we have higher employee strength. And we have been looking at a “convergence model” as our next step,” says Nidhi.

At Mudichur, birders chanced upon a Java sparrow while having gone there in the hope of seeing another bird species. The Java sparrow is a breeding resident in parts of Indonesia. And this particular individual is likely a captive bird that had slipped out of a cage, raising questions about the sordid side of the pet trade

PRINCE FREDERICK

The backdrop can sometimes cast a sombre shadow over a stage pulsating with a grand achievement. Knowing the backstory can automatically signal restraint, cutting out celebration, even justified celebration, without a twinge of regret. An extensively reported event this year would make this idea clearer. Royal Challengers Bangalore cut out the victory parade following their triumph in IPL 2026 clearly because the “backdrop” of a tragic stampede the previous year loomed large casting a long shadow over a merry moment that played out on a grand stage. Something parallel to that, sans the sombreness, happened recently in the Chennai Metropolitan Area.

Over a week’s duration, the start date being September 19, Mudichur in Tambaram witnessed a parade of birders out to catch a glimpse of a rare avian, so rare that when news of its sighting hit their “auriculars”, some dropped their telephoto zoom lens. It was a Java sparrow (*Padda oryzivora*) found in parts of Indonesia, Java being one of them, where they are meant to be found. The sad story (actually, the backstory birders out here were aware of) is that this bird is also found where it has no business poking its beak around, and it is not to be blamed for that. Aviculture and, in a larger sense, human beings’ innate ability honed by greed to interfere with Nature’s delicate but sound systems. The birders sensed this bird could have slipped past the open shutter of some cage

here, and that knowledge tempered the sense of having found something rare. They clicked away still, but there was restraint in their posts about the sighting.

Birders Jithesh Babu and Saravanan Manian had discovered the Java sparrow in Mudichur serendipitously while seeking to pay another bird a visit, a passage migrant in Chennai.

“On September 19, we were there looking for the European roller, which was reported to have been sighted at Mudichur,” says Jithesh. The European roller (*Coracias garulus*) not showing up immediately, the birders ventured a little further in than they had expected to, and

there it was, a surprise in a package of red, pink, grey, black and white: a Java sparrow with, probably until recently, a local address on its calling card.

If the European roller had a sense of humour and the power of speech to express it, it surely would have rasped out “and you thought I was the surprise!” The European roller breeds in Europe and winters in Africa and is known to ink in Chennai as a pit stop on its iconic long-distance migration, almost treated as a sub category in migration, being dubbed “roller migration”. Last year, European roller sighting was reported from the Broken Bridge area of the Adyar Estuary.

Java sparrow and (above) European roller at Mudichur on September 19.
PHOTOS: JITHESH BABU



Campaign at Chromepet, Perungalathur stations

MSSW students conducted 'Railway Level Crossing Safety Awareness Programme' with a street play and a safety pledge

Students of Master of Social Work (Self-Finance) at Madras School of Social Work conducted a three-day awareness campaign on railway safety at Chennai suburban railway stations.

Held in collaboration with Indian Railways, the 'Railway Level Crossing Safety Awareness Programme' took place at Chromepet, Perungalathur and Perambur railway stations.

The campaign focused on creating awareness among college students, train commuters, and the public about the safety associated with railway tracks, footboard travel, trespassing, and unsafe shortcuts.

M. Vasudevan, Indian Railway Traffic Service, Senior Divisional Safety Officer, Indian Railways, in-



troduced the programme. Manikandan, Safety Supervisor, Indian Railways, delivered safety briefings and interacted with the public, ex-

plaining railway safety procedures and the risks associated with unsafe practices around railway premises. The commuters were en-

Students with posters at Perungalathur station.

couraged to use footbridges and other authorized crossing facilities.

The campaign carried the key message 'Shortcuts Lead to Short Life', highlighting the fact that trains cannot stop immediately and that crossing railway tracks or using unauthorized shortcuts can have fatal consequences.

As part of the campaign, the students presented street plays depicting the dangers of footboard travel, railway-track trespassing and other unsafe behaviours, said a release.

The students also organised a public safety pledge, encouraging commuters to commit to following railway safety practices. Safety slogans were raised during the cam-

paing, and awareness pamphlets with essential railway safety information were distributed to commuters and the public.

An unexpected incident during the campaign further demonstrated the importance of railway safety and immediate intervention. The railway staff found a person in a crisis situation on the railway tracks. Students, along with railway personnel, responded immediately and helped rescue the individual.

The awareness initiative was student-led by Kavin Sundar, Yugendran E., Reanne R. Fewkes, Nitya Satish, Yazhini Muthupandi and Staines Kennedy R.K., with manpower support from Nithyan J and Jaylyn Jude. The students worked under Professor R. Ramachandran, faculty, Madras School of Social Work.

A photo contest for the deaf

Rotary club of Chennai Crown and Madras photobloggers are organising an exclusive photo contest for the deaf on nature conservation, as part of International Week of Deaf Awareness. The link for submission is <http://tinyurl.com/YAA-VARUM-PHOTOCONTEST>. The last date for submission is September.

Winners of the contest will be honoured during Wildlife Week 2026 in October.

Earlier, on September 20, also as part of the International Week of Deaf Awareness, a nature photo walk was organised at Nanmangalam reserve forest exclusively for the deaf community, with interpreter support, through a collaborative effort of Care Earth Trust, Tamil Nadu Forest Department, Madras Photobloggers, and Rotary Club of Chennai Crown.

Thirty-five deaf participants actively took part in the photowalk. Officials from Care Earth Trust and the Tamil Nadu Forest Department introduced participants to the rich diversity of flora and fauna, helping them observe and appreciate the natural environment around them.



Participants captured their experiences through mobile phones and cameras, exploring nature through their own perspectives and creativity. The programme provided an inclusive space for the deaf community to connect with nature, learn about biodiversity, and express themselves through photography and the upcoming photocontest exclusively for the deaf.

Rotary club of Chennai Crown and Madras photobloggers helped the participants in documenting nature, says a press release

Participants captured their experiences through mobile phones and cameras, exploring nature through their own perspectives and creativity. The programme provided an inclusive space for the deaf community to connect with nature, learn about biodiversity, and express themselves through photography and the upcoming photocontest exclusively for the deaf.



College in Chromepet launches 'Agentic AI Campus'

To celebrate its 59th year, Shrimathi Devkunvar Nanalal Bhatt (SDNB) Vaishnav College for Women in Chromepet has launched an Agentic AI Campus. The initiative was launched at an event held at the college on September 23, marking a step towards building an AI-first campus and preparing students and faculty for an evolving workplace.

The initiative aims to equip students and faculty with practical AI skills that can support teaching, learning, academic exploration and career readiness.

Gemini Enterprise is Google Cloud's AI platform for organisations, enabling users to access information across connected institutional resources, work with an AI assistant and use AI agents to support tasks and workflows. These agents can assist with multi-step activities, extending the use of AI beyond simply answering questions, said a release.

The occasion included the



formal handover of the certificate to Nimish Tolia, Secretary and Managing Trustee, SDNB Vaishnav College for Women by Navisha Prabhakar, Regional Head - Education, South & West, Google Cloud. Arun Kumar, Director, Ankercloud; Vineet Parameswaran, Country Head - Strategic Partnerships, Google Cloud; Satyen Makhija, Partner - Engineering, AI & Data, Deloitte; Deb Banerjee,

Partner, Deloitte; Kamlesh Vyas, Partner, Deloitte; Tarun R. Kodnani, DoyenAI; and K. Kanthimathi, Principal, SDNB Vaishnav College for Women were among those present.

As part of the initiative, SDNB Vaishnav College has partnered with Deloitte, Ankercloud and DoyenAI for consulting, technology and adoption support, added the release.

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VELS University honours 1,000 school teachers



VELS University organised the VELS Teachers Excellence Awards 2026 across its various campuses. As part of the Teachers' Day celebrations, the felicitation ceremony was held at the VELS University campus in Pallavaram. Premalatha Vijayakant, MLA, Virudhachalam Constituency and general secretary, DMDK, graced the occasion as chief guest and felicitated the teachers, says a press release.

Preethaa Ganesh, vice president, VELS University, said that "teaching is the finest profession, as it creates and shapes all other professions."

Premalatha Vijayakant recalled the teacher who had a significant influence on her during her school years. She said: "Teachers carry the great responsibility of guiding students on the right path. Captain



▼ Premalatha Vijayakant with the awardees

Vijayakant deeply understood the importance of education and extended educational assistance to thousands of students to help them continue their studies. Behind the success of every student, there is the contribution of a teacher who guided and encouraged them. There was such a teacher in my

own life as well. A teacher named Loganathan guided me and played an important role in shaping me into the person I am today. Though he is no longer with us, I will always remember and acknowledge his contribution to all my achievements."

The VELS Teachers Excellence Awards 2026 have been instituted to recognise and honour the dedicated service of teachers who play a significant role in shaping students' knowledge, skills, character and future, says the press release.

The event was attended by Arthi Ganesh, pro chancellor, VELS University; M. Baskaran, vice chancellor; M. Chandrasekaran, registrar, and other senior members of the university administration.

K Mohandas Memorial Award for former Tamil Nadu DGP



K Ramanujam, former Director General of Police, Tamil Nadu, receives the award.

B Force, a charitable trust based in Chennai, operating with the aim of providing and facilitating the Tamil Nadu Police force and their families with medical assistance, specifically in the areas of management of cancer, was launched as a tribute to K. Mohandas IPS, former Director General of Police, Tamil Nadu and his wife, Santha Mohandas. K. Mohandas belonged to the 1956 batch of the Indian Police Service, Tamil Nadu cadre. The trust was established by the four daughters of the Mohandas couple.

A press release from B Force points out that to commemorate

its anniversary, B Force bestows an award instituted as "The K Mohandas Memorial Award". This award is conferred upon a past senior police officer who has contributed to the police force beyond the call of his duty.

This year, on September 22, 2026, to commemorate its 19th anniversary, B Force conducted an awards ceremony at Amir Mahal. Recipient of the prestigious award is K Ramanujam IPS, former Director General of Police, Tamil Nadu. As chief guest, Nawabzada Mohammed Asif Ali, Dewan to the Prince of Arcot presented and felicitated the decorated officer with the award.

City ophthalmologist honoured at conference in Bangkok



Ophthalmologist from Chennai Dr D P Prakash was invited to give a keynote speech on eye care at the United Nations Conference Centre in Bangkok on September 25. The summit was on sustainable living and wellbeing, says a press release.

His presentation was titled "The World- First Artificial Intelligence Based Vision Care System."

In his address, the chief eye surgeon of American Eye Care Centre

highlighted how India is losing a gross national income of 646 billion rupees due to the 70 million vision-impaired population apart from the 4.9 million blind people, says a press release.

He spoke a proprietary Agentic AI Technology known as "The Seranova" which would integrate every aspect of the vision testing process right from history to diagnosis and eye wear selection and referral, adds the press release.

The AI also generates what he calls "The Prakash Perfect Vision Score" that enables the patient to understand if his eyes are normal or not, says the press release.

Delegates from various member countries and dignitaries from WHO, Red Cross International and ambassadors to Thailand from Morocco, Nepal South Africa, Russia, and Hungary took part.

On the occasion, he received the Global Change Maker Award for his contribution towards advancing eye care and sustainable health care development from Dr. Giovanni Jing, UNESCO, Italy.

135 school teachers in the limelight at Guru Dhakshina 2026



Agurchand Manmull Jain College, recently hosted its much-anticipated annual ceremony, Guru Dhakshina 2026, a celebration of gratitude recognising teachers at

the Bhagwan Mahaveer Gyan Bhavan.

The college paid tribute to 135 school teachers, chosen from across schools in and around

Chennai, says a press release.

The ceremony was graced by an eminent panel of guests and dignitaries. Film actor, motivational speaker and educationist Dhamu was chief guest. Founder of Farmguru Agritech was the guest of honour.

The event was also attended by Udhay Kumar Chordia, secretary; Hemant P. Chordia, associate secretary; N. Venkataramanan, director; M.M. Ramya, dean; and R. Surekha, deputy dean.

The ceremony featured a symbolic gesture of a student seeking blessings from a teacher, capturing the Guru-Shishya tradition.

Season two of Battle of Brains

Battle of Brains, an inter-school quiz, is back with its second season. Organised by Casagrand, in association with Nexus Consulting, schools across Chennai can register teams of two students from classes 6 to 10 at no cost. Registrations are open until October 5, 2026.

The event will be held from October 10 to November 15, 2026.

The winning teams from the zonal rounds will advance to the city final, where they will compete for the Battle of Brains Season 2 title.

The second season will also extend the quizzing experience beyond students with a dedicated parents and teachers quiz.